

Top Ten Things I wish I had known as a Freshman Collegiate Athlete

1. **The recruiting period is over.** This means your new coach, who seemed so likeable and held you in such high regards, is no longer obligated to tell you how good you are. You traded in your last bargaining chip when you decided to come to this school. Now it's the coaches' turn to mold you into a player they can use. This means a lot of conversations less focused on what you're doing well, and more focused on what you need to do better. This also means direct critical feedback, sometimes in the form of shouting. Remember that all of your teammates go through this. If it really gets to be too much, review point #9. Don't be afraid to cry.

2. Also about coaches, **they will probably be somewhat different than you imagined them to be.** This isn't necessarily a bad thing. That super nice, smiley guy you met on your recruiting trips probably wouldn't be able to create the top-notch team you wanted to be a part of anyways. Try to reserve your judgment until the end of season, and then try to reserve it to the end of off-season...and then keep withholding judgment until the end of your college career. Because if you're like me, you have a coach that's right a lot more than you want them to be and you don't want to admit that to yourself quite yet. So respect the decisions your coaches make; even if you've heard it a thousand times, they probably know best.

3. **Being a good teammate doesn't just mean being a good player.** So many college freshmen think their job is done once practice is over, but really being a good teammate means so much more than that. It means encouraging others even if they are the same position as you. It means showing up early to help set up, even if it's not your job. It means studying and getting good grades so your coaches aren't constantly anxious about eligibility. Even if you're not playing, or even close to playing, you can always be a good teammate.

4. **You will always be overwhelmingly exhausted,** even on your occasional day off when you haven't moved out of your bed since you woke up three hours ago. But also remember that....

5. **You will never be as exhausted as your team captain.** Your team captain knows to run to go shag balls, not walk. They know to finish first in every punishment run, and most of them know that their college career is coming to a close so every drill should be held on to as tightly as possible. You, on the other hand, do not know this. You are actually pretty clueless about the whole thing. On top of everything else the team captain has to worry about, they also have to make sure you and the other freshmen don't screw up too badly. So please, cut them some slack.

6. **There is no social life during season.** You might want to go to a party, meet new people, or even stay up past 11 p.m. for once but all of this changes when you're playing Notre Dame the next day and you need your full 8 hours. It's okay; the parties that your classmates rave about are probably not even that great (or at least that's what you tell yourself because it's not like you'll ever get to go anyways).

7. **Since you don't really have a social life, this makes your teammates even more important.** They are now the people you spend over 70% of your time with. They will be your best friends, the bridesmaids or groomsmen at your wedding. Make no mistake, you probably won't be super close with all of them. But it is your job to develop at least a respectful relationship with each person, even if you "don't get where they're coming from" sometimes. It doesn't matter. Just like you can't choose family, you can't choose teammates. But you love them anyways.

8. **You will look like crap a lot.** Sweatpants are your new best friend and everyone else is just going to have to accept that.

9. **You will cry at some point.** I don't care if you're starting, have a ton of new friends, and good grades. At some point things will overwhelm you and you will cry. It's okay, if it's happening to you, you can bet it's happening to some of your freshmen teammates. Talk to them about it. You don't have to fake like you have it together all the time...unless your coach is walking by. Then you should probably wipe those tears up and stop sniffing.

10. **The season is ridiculously long.** You'll actually feel yourself graying and wrinkling, the season seems so long. There will be days where you would rather have a root canal operated on than go to practice. Soreness is your new normal, and you've even entertained thoughts of quitting, but then finally the last day comes and of course you're sad, but you're mainly relieved. You think to yourself, *I don't know if I could have gone a week longer.* And then you go back to your dorm, go to bed, wake up the next morning, and want to play again. You'll go to the gym or field just to hit the ball around and break up these now incredibly boring days that don't have practice in the middle of them. You'll linger around your coaches offices because you actually miss them. This is how you know you made the right decision. If after all those practices and the traveling and the meetings and the crying...if after all that you still find yourself missing freshman season the minute after it ended, you know you were meant to play in college. You're at the right place. You'll be okay.

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